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APPS



Slack bolsters search
with AI, adds
transcriptions and
summaries for huddles



As the race to bake AI features into productivity apps intensifies, Slack is bolstering search on its app with AI features, adding transcription and summaries for huddles, and a way to see recaps of channels and threads.

Using AI, Slack now lets you search across channels as well as connected apps (like Google Drive, Salesforce, and Teams) to surface relevant files and conversations. This feature will be available on Slack's Enterprise plans.

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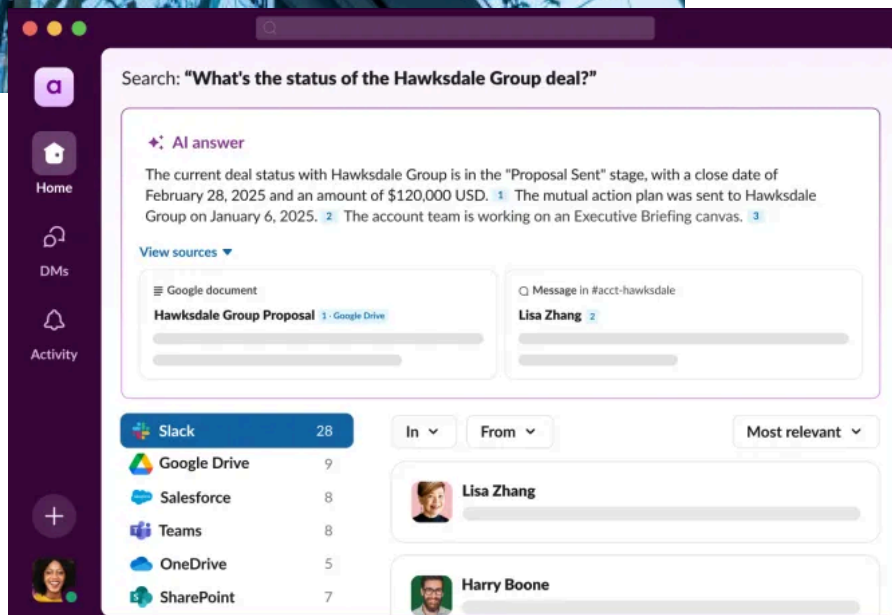
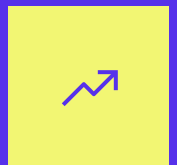


IMAGE CREDITS: SLACK

The company is also using AI to bolster Huddles, the company's voice and video chat feature, with call transcriptions and summaries, and the app will automatically highlight key action items brought up in calls.

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And to help users catch up on conversations, Slack will offer summaries of messages in a channel or thread if you were away.

The company said that it will roll out a way for users to get a summary of another user's profile, showing their role and recent work. There are also plans for a feature in the Activities tab that will surface action items when you're looking at a message mentioning you.

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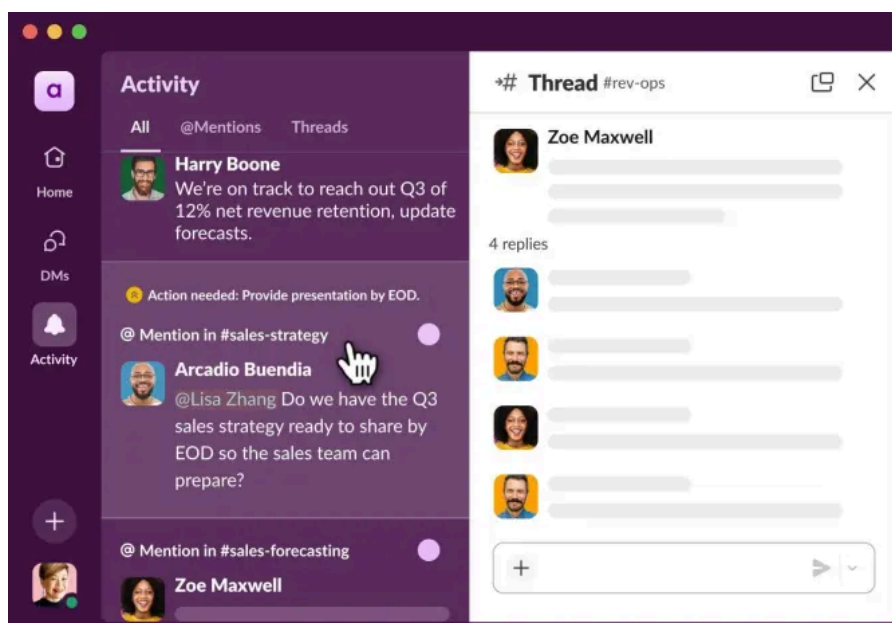


IMAGE CREDITS: SLACK

Slack added that it is working on a feature that would let you use AI to explain a message in the context of the given conversation.

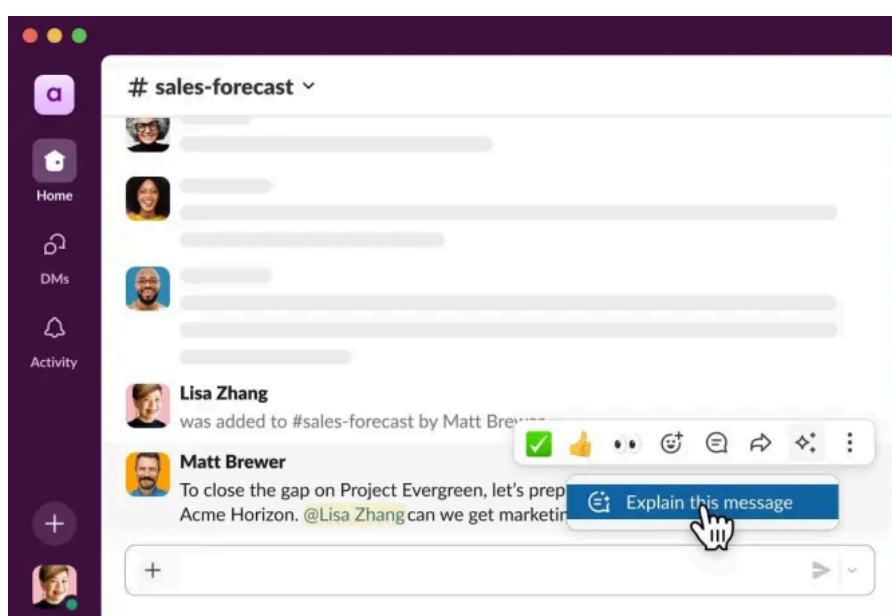


IMAGE CREDITS: SLACK

For Canvas, a collaborative panel that lets users share guides, documents, and information, the company plans to add an AI-powered writing assistant that would help users create a canvas from any conversation or change the existing content's formatting.



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The app's also getting a design makeover — we're getting a unified space for all shared files, lists, and Canvas items.

The story is updated to clarify that Slack offers AI search with integrations only to Enterprise customers.

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Ivan covers global consumer tech developments at TechCrunch. He is based out of India and has previously...

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Microsoft unbundles Office and Teams globally following years-long criticism

Manish Singh — 3:02 AM PDT · April 1, 2024

IMAGE CREDITS:
JAAP ARRIENS/NURPHOTO / GETTY IMAGES

Microsoft has introduced new versions of [Microsoft 365](#) and Office 365 subscription services that

exclude its business collaboration chat offering Teams following [scrutiny from the European Union regulator](#) and complaints from rival Slack.

The move — which some analysts say is unlikely to change the commercial growth trajectory of Office 365 — follows Microsoft [agreeing to sell Office 365 suite sans Microsoft Teams offering in the EU and Switzerland](#) last year. At the time, the software giant said it was making the changes to address the concerns raised by the European Commission.

“Globally consistent licensing helps ensure clarity for customers and streamline decision making and negotiations,” the company [wrote](#) in a blog post Monday. The company introduced Teams as [a complementary offering to the Office 365 suite](#) in 2016. It has amassed over 320 million users.

Microsoft said it is also introducing a new standalone Teams offering for enterprise customers outside the EU and Switzerland.

Though Microsoft has long allowed businesses to pay separately for Teams, it has also offered the service bundled in the widely popular Office 365 suite. The latter has upset some competitors with some asserting that the tech giant was leveraging its position in an unjust manner to gain a competitive edge.

Slack, owned by [Salesforce](#), has termed Microsoft’s actions “illegal” in the past, alleging that the Windows-maker forced installation of Teams to customers through its market-dominant productivity suite and [hid the true cost of the chat and video service](#).

Microsoft didn’t address these concerns in its blog, but said as part of the change, it is offering flexibility to its existing customers, allowing them to maintain their current bundled package that

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For new customers, Microsoft has introduced standalone pricing for Teams at \$5.25 per user per month. Additionally, Office packages without Teams will be available at prices ranging from \$7.75 to \$54.75, depending on the specific package and features included.

Existing suites with Teams	New Suites without Teams (after Apr. 1)	Pricing*
Office 365 E1/E3/E5 and Microsoft 365 E3/E5 suites with Teams no longer sold to new subscribers.	Office 365 E1 (no Teams)	\$7.75
Available only to customers with existing licenses that include Microsoft Teams as of April 1, 2024 outside the EEA and Switzerland.	Office 365 E3 (no Teams)	\$20.75
	Office 365 E5 (no Teams)	\$35.75
	Microsoft 365 E3 (no Teams)	\$33.75
	Microsoft 365 E5 (no Teams)	\$54.75
New Microsoft Teams Standalone		Pricing*
Microsoft Teams Enterprise		\$5.25

THE NEW MICROSOFT SUITE OFFERING WITH TEAMS (IMAGE: MICROSOFT)

Existing suites with Teams	Pricing*	New suites without Teams (starting Apr. 1)	Pricing*
Microsoft 365 Business Basic	\$6.00	Microsoft 365 Business Basic (no Teams)	\$4.75
Microsoft 365 Business Standard	\$12.50	Microsoft 365 Business Standard (no Teams)	\$10.25
Microsoft 365 Business Premium	\$22.00	Microsoft 365 Business Premium (no Teams)	\$19.75

MICROSOFT IS ALSO INTRODUCING A NEW VARIANT OF MICROSOFT 365 BUSINESS THAT EXCLUDES TEAMS.

In a note seen by TechCrunch, Morgan Stanley analysts estimated that Microsoft's Monday decision is "unlikely to change the O365 commercial growth trajectory, as more consolidation (not less) seems to be the direction of travel for CIO's due to macro pressures and technological progress like GenAI driving stronger gains for the broader suites and deeper data sets."

"Further, providing more choice for purchasing Teams clearly illustrates its compelling value, at just \$5.25 per user per month for New Microsoft Teams Enterprise (standalone), which compares to Slack Pro at \$7.25/mo and Slack Business+ at \$12.50/mo. The price reduction in the Enterprise Suites without Teams is only \$2.25, yet the Standalone cost is \$5.25. For new customers, this equates to a pricing increase. Using Teams in F1 SKU's costs only \$0.50 per user per month and using Teams in Business SKU's cost only \$1.25-\$2.25 per user per month," wrote the analysts.

Exhibit 8: 76% of CIOs Use Office 365 Today....Expected to Increase to 83% Within 3 Years With Another 3% Still Using Office On-Prem in 3 Years

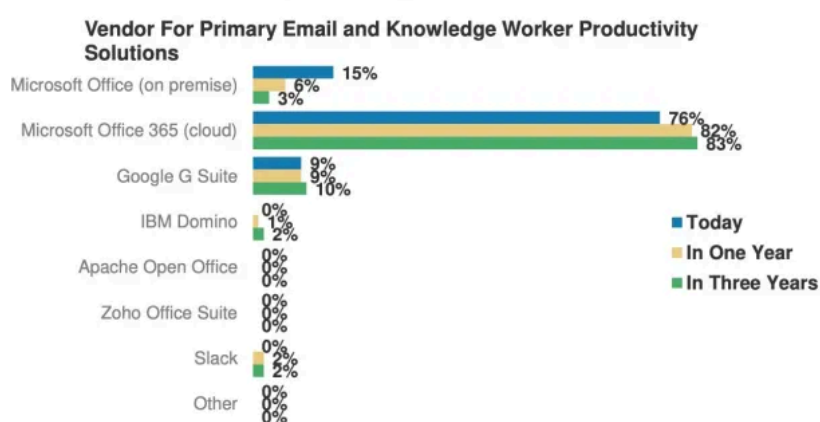


IMAGE CREDITS: MORGAN STANLEY

The story was updated with details from Microsoft's official blog and Morgan Stanley's comment.

**Manish Singh**

Reporter, India |

Manish Singh is a senior reporter at TechCrunch, covering India's startup scene and venture capital investments. H...

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New Salesforce developer tools look to tighten integration with Slack

Kyle Wiggers — 5:00 AM PDT · April 27, 2022

IMAGE CREDITS
ALEXI ROSENFELD / GETTY IMAGES

This week during its TrailblazerDX 2022 conference,

Salesforce announced a new set of low-code developer tools and integrations intended to bring Slack and Salesforce's broader software portfolio closer together. Called Salesforce Platform for Slack, Salesforce says that the new software development toolkit will "empower" Salesforce developers to build custom Slack apps that ostensibly improve the customer experience at their organizations.

In the two years since Salesforce acquired Slack for \$27.7 billion, the company has made progress — albeit slow — in positioning the chat platform as a central part of its product ecosystem. Last August, Salesforce announced Slack integrations with Sales Cloud, Service Cloud, Marketing Cloud and Tableau, including workflow notifications that update Slack channels when changes to a marketing journey are made. More recently, Salesforce launched new media sharing options in Slack and a government tier, GovSlack, designed for public sector customers with strong compliance requirements.

"Since Slack's acquisition by Salesforce was completed, we've been firmly focused on how the unison of these two companies will result in better, more seamless outcomes for our customers — and deliver unique value for developer and business communities," Rob Seaman, Slack's SVP of platform product management, told TechCrunch in an email interview. "Salesforce Platform for Slack is an exciting next step to deeply integrating [Salesforce] across Slack by making it easier than ever to put the functionality — the actions, workflows, data and business insights — from Salesforce right in Slack, the place where people are already working."

Toward this end, the new Salesforce Flow in Slack toolkit — a part of Salesforce Platform for Slack —

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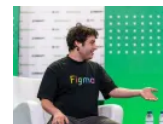


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lets developers build Slack automations with support for Salesforce data and actions. With Slack Actions, developers can automate basic tasks like creating Slack channels to collaborate with stakeholders and sending account status updates to colleagues. Screen Flows, another component of Flow in Slack, allows users to build multi-step workflows in Salesforce that can be reused within Slack.

Salesforce's low-code workflow tool aims to unify CRM giant's largest acquisitions



Salesforce is a big, complex set of services, which has been augmented via acquisition with several other big complex services, including MuleSoft, Tableau and Slack, three companies the CRM

giant acquired in recent years. The company has been looking for ways to make all of these tools (including Salesforce itself) work better together, and it

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Salesforce Platform for Slack also introduces the Apex SDK for Slack, which lets developers use Salesforce's [Apex](#) language to fetch customer records and create reusable views. The new SDK — which uses [Block Kit](#), Slack's UI framework for Slack apps, to automatically generate the necessary frontend code — also supports routing events between Slack and Salesforce and vice versa, without middleware.

TE

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“Currently, developers build complex integrations that involve third-party middleware solutions, complicated data and metadata mappings, event routing, and many other prerequisites. But Apex SDK for Slack allows Salesforce developers to get right to building using the code and tools that they’re already familiar with,” Seaman said. “As an example, a developer might want to build a shortcut in Slack that looks up customer usage data and displays it in an account team channel. You can build a simple app that uses a Salesforce Object Query Language (SOQL) query to collect the data of interest and display it in Slack. The Apex SDK takes care of all of the underlying plumbing so you can just focus on your business logic. Alternatively, developers who are already using or working with Salesforce apps can use the Apex SDK, with its familiar coding language, to extend those apps to integrate with Slack.”

To accompany the release of Salesforce Platform for Slack, Salesforce launched three Slack apps in beta (ahead of general availability in June) that were built using the new developer tools: Sales Cloud for Slack, Service Cloud for Slack and Marketing Cloud for Slack. Sales Cloud for Slack automates deal status updates to sales teams and maintains records in Salesforce, while Service Cloud for Slack assigns service cases to team members as they come in. Marketing Cloud for

Slack, meanwhile, automatically alerts sales teams in Slack when leads are generated.

“We’ll continue to build integrations between Salesforce and Slack to empower customers with the ability to leverage Salesforce’s comprehensive system of record, business insights, powerful tools, and deep platform capabilities — right from where people are already working together in Slack,” Seaman said. “We’ll have integrations for each of the Salesforce cloud products and industry solutions. We expect many to become generally available this year and we’ll have more to share as those integrations are released. ”

When Salesforce announced its plans to buy Slack in 2020, analysts were skeptical that the company — which paid a [substantial premium](#) for Slack shares — could successfully layer the chat platform on top of its existing offerings. UBS analysts wrote at the time that the synergy story “wasn’t convincing,” while Mizuho Securities analysts said that they were “uncertain how well [Salesforce] would monetize this asset.”

In 2020, [analysts](#) surveyed by Refinitiv projected that Slack would generate \$876.3 million in revenue in fiscal year 2020. (Slack had 156,000 paying customers and more than 10 million users as of February 2021). That’s a fraction of the \$17.1 billion in revenue Salesforce notched that same year.

Salesforce Platform for Slack might be Salesforce’s most meaningful step yet in the direction of platform unification — and cross-selling. But in the face of continued competition from rivals such as Microsoft Teams, Google Chat and even Zoom, it’s unclear to what extent tighter integration with Salesforce products will convince skeptics to shell out for a Slack subscription.

“By empowering more than 11 million Salesforce developers to build time-saving Slack apps natively on Salesforce Platform without learning a new programming language, we’re creating an opportunity to massively scale Slack apps and workflows across both Salesforce and Slack,” Seaman said. “No other vendor in the marketplace has ever built anything like this for Slack, and it’s an example of how Slack and Salesforce are jointly innovating their platforms together to make give every team, department and partner what they need to move the business forward.”

Salesforce expects Flow in Slack to launch in beta in June and become generally available in October. A pilot for Apex SDK for Slack will tentatively roll out in June and transition to generally availability next February.

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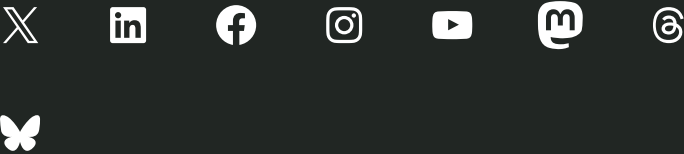
Kyle Wiggers

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Kyle Wiggers was TechCrunch’s AI Editor until June 2025.
His writing has appeared in VentureBeat and Digital...

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